

# Charles Russell Speechlys

Complete firm and application research — sectors, responsible business, values, clients, culture, awards, market position, application guidance and personal notes.

**Niche:** Private capital, alongside household-name and high-net-worth clients  
**London specialism:** Art & luxury  
**UK offices:** London, Guildford, Cheltenham  
**Apprenticeship:** Up to 8 teams sat in during the programme; international secondment options (Dubai, Hong Kong, Singapore)

|                                    |   |
|------------------------------------|---|
| 1. Firm Overview & Focus           | — |
| 2. Sectors                         | — |
| 3. Responsible Business & Pro Bono | — |
| 4. Values                          | — |
| 5. Locations                       | — |
| 6. Clients                         | — |
| 7. Culture                         | — |
| 8. Awards & Recognition            | — |
| 9. Position in the Market          | — |
| 10. Notable Practice — Family      | — |
| 11. Application Guidance           | — |
| 12. Qualities Sought               | — |
| 13. About the Apprenticeship       | — |
| 14. Personal Fit Notes             | — |

## 1. Firm Overview & Focus

---

- Focus on private capital, though the firm also works with household names and high-net-worth individuals
- A full-service firm
- No dedicated Art & Luxury team as such — lawyers across the firm come across this work naturally; apprentices wanting more exposure are encouraged to raise it directly with their supervisor

## 2. Sectors

---

ART & LUXURY   AVIATION   PRIVATE WEALTH   HEALTHCARE   RETAIL & CONSUMER   TECH, MEDIA & COMMS   SPORT

TRANSACTIONAL / CORPORATE M&A

- Private Wealth covers individuals, wills, probate, and estates and creditors
- Retail & Consumer work connects to IP issues like patent and copyright infringement (e.g. copying originating in China), which can directly harm retail and consumer businesses
- The corporate team's transactional work centres on M&A, working collaboratively to get deals done
- Litigation strengths span IP, private wealth (wills and probate), and commercial and corporate restructuring and insolvency

## 3. Responsible Business & Pro Bono

---

Framed around a duty to help level the playing field — improving access to justice, access to education, and access to professional opportunities for disadvantaged groups. This work sits within a wider Community Impact Programme spanning justice, charity and opportunity.

- Participation in the **Greece Pro Bono Collaborative** — training and deploying lawyers to Athens and the Greek island of Lesbos to support asylum seekers
- Supporting individual survivors of the Windrush scandal in their fight for justice — one of the leading firms in the **Windrush Legal Initiative**, working alongside legal charity partner Greater Manchester Immigration Aid Unit and seven other firms
- 9 key charity partners of the Charles Russell Speechlys Foundation
- 80+ organisations provided with pro bono legal advice
- 900+ individuals supported with pro bono legal advice

## 4. Values

---

Firm values: **Authentic, Collaborative, Forward Looking and Committed** — each with a specific internal nuance.

- Look out for each other; actively seek out opportunities to adopt a collaborative mindset; draw strength from differences; share knowledge to improve
- Driven to produce the highest quality work possible, pushing to go beyond the obvious brief and consider deeper personal and business needs
- Energy and determination; honest, confident and considerate; long-term thinking
- Act as strategic advisors beyond pure legal considerations, building thoughtful, trusting, long-term relationships
- Humane and pragmatic — catering to the needs of people with complex lives, including representing high-profile individuals often in the public eye
- Cross-disciplinary approach spanning tax and trusts, disputes, corporate, property, and reputation management
- Clear, realistic advice
- Reputation management work requires rapid reaction, negotiation and action — media issues often require coordinated international advice, defamation response, and ongoing monitoring of a client's digital presence
- Tax work links closely to wealth structuring — including drafting wills with tax exposure in mind, trusts, and advice on beneficiary rights

## 5. Locations

---

- UK offices: London, Guildford, and Cheltenham
- London is where the firm's art and luxury work is concentrated
- Real estate work is covered across all three UK offices

## 6. Clients

---

Notable clients include Bill's, Nike, Hotel Chocolat, Etihad Airways, Itsu, The Ivy, Caffè Nero, and David Lloyd. The firm handles a significant volume of business/commercial contract work, including influencer collaborations, alongside prestigious private clients. Its

real estate team is one of the largest in London and is Band 1 ranked.

## 7. Culture

---

- Lots of socialisation and firm events; a people-first culture
- Apprentices are exposed to a significant amount of experience — described as rare for an apprentice
- Works closely with global offices, including regular international coordination (e.g. calls with Hong Kong at 10am)
- Presence in over 120 countries — where the firm doesn't have its own office, it works through groups of expert contacts and existing client relationships instead
- Strong networking opportunities throughout the apprenticeship
- Apprentices can choose from a wide range of seats, sitting in up to 8 different teams over the course of the programme — the range of available work is described as what sets the apprenticeship apart from other routes

## 8. Awards & Recognition

---

- Legal tech award — Most Innovative Firm of the Year, reflecting the firm's approach to shaping the future of legal services; substantial growth following the "Russell Up" programme after a Director of Applied Client Solutions (ACS) was appointed in 2023, and recent adoption of Harvey AI
- Best Use Case in AI — recognised for a cross-border UK/Swiss litigation matter, where the firm deployed Relativity's aiR for Review almost immediately after its market release during the disclosure phase, saving around 180 manual review hours
- Ranked in the top 20 highest-scoring firms in the latest Lamp House Strategy review of law firms' responsible business activity — Lamp House Strategy is a legal-sector insights specialist that scored 150 firms across Governance, People and Planet

## 9. Position in the Market

---

- A growing real estate team
- Deep private capital expertise
- An Advanced Client Solutions team focused on smarter service and better-quality delivery
- Tailored, pragmatic, realistic advice as a core differentiator
- A wave of new partner hires across IP, real estate, and the Middle East

## 10. Notable Practice — Family

---

Charles Russell Speechlys has one of the leading Family teams in the UK, specialising in inheritance disputes and family mediation.

## 11. Application Guidance

---

The firm's suggested structure for application answers follows a simple three-part flow: state your interest point (e.g. which practice areas draw you to the firm), give concrete evidence (e.g. a real news story, case, or experience that sparked that interest), then explain how that initial interest developed into a genuine aspiration toward a specific legal career path. The "evidence" stage doesn't have to be a news headline — it could equally be a person who inspired you, or work experience in a different sector (e.g. retail or hospitality) that revealed why you might suit a legal career.

- Avoid overdramatic language (e.g. describing something as an "unprecedented opportunity")
- Show your full chain of reasoning, not just a conclusion
- Reference specific legal work and tasks, with a clear link to what you actually did
- Use **PEEL** (Point, Evidence, Explain, Link) for general questions, and **STAR** (Situation, Task, Action, Result) for work experience-based questions
- Include a genuinely good example of a time you've worked in a team
- Reflect on a specific deal, case, client, or pro bono matter, and explain why it mattered to you
- Aim for roughly 2-3 points per question
- Be ready to identify areas where the firm itself could grow
- Pinpoint at least two sectors you're genuinely interested in working in
- Back every claim with research, evidence and a specific example

Show your genuine first "pull" toward that area of law, and keep it authentic — authenticity is one of the firm's core stated values, and choosing examples clearly relevant to the firm's actual departments shows real research into their day-to-day work.

## 12. Qualities Sought

---

Willingness to learn is explicitly noted as making the whole experience easier; candidates are also encouraged to acknowledge that the freedom the role offers comes with its own challenges, not just benefits.

## 13. About the Apprenticeship

---

- Strong quality of work throughout is intended to support a smooth transition to full qualification
- The academic element is taken seriously, and candidates are expected to be strong academically as well as practically
- Plenty is on offer, but it takes real hard work to get through the programme
- A genuine passion for studying the law and seeing it applied in practice is valued
- The firm has offered this apprenticeship route for 7 years, and is described as understanding how much qualifying ultimately means to apprentices
- International secondment options include Dubai, Hong Kong and Singapore

When describing your own experience in applications, detail actions taken in the first person — how you personally achieved a goal — and reflect honestly on what you would have done differently and what you learned from it.

## 14. Personal Fit Notes

---

Space to develop personal talking points connecting genuine interests to the firm's specific sectors and values.

- Genuine reasons for applying matter more than generic ones — the firm explicitly wants to see a real, personal "pull" toward a specific area of law, not just a well-researched but impersonal answer
- The firm's Family team (inheritance disputes, family mediation) and Real Estate practice are worth using as concrete, well-researched examples of departments genuinely of interest, rather than referencing the firm only in general terms

Sources: charlesrussellspeechlys.com sector, insights and careers pages; firm press coverage; Lamp House Strategy responsible business review. Compiled as private research — verify current salary, deadline and programme details against the live listing before applying.